varna system—has been so powerful that its hold in the subcontinent, notwithstanding Ashoka and Ambedkar, has never been seriously undermined from the time when the Vedas were composed down to the present. The Buddha and his best-known disciple Ashoka seem to have recognized that in order to combat and counter a system of brainwashing as powerful as Brahmanical Hinduism required the use, for different ends, of some of the same storytelling techniques. This basically meant ensuring that the Buddhist message, while asserting a socially inclusive view—both the lowly and the exalted could occupy the same moral plane by following a zealous path and achieve heaven (‘svaga’) equally—was not delivered in ways that were out of line with notions of the sacred that had been internalized by caste Hindus. In other words, the commingling of gods with ordinary people was a motif that Ashoka saw the value of for the spread of a dissenting faith within an old culture: to that extent, it was new wine being made more heady by being poured out of an old and recognizable bottle.

The same initial message also shows purposive variety: Ashoka suggests that, his own subjects apart, people on the borders learn about what has moved him in this new direction. So, from the time when he began publicly communicating through edicts, he presents himself as a ruler not merely providing an example to his own existing subjects, but equally to potential converts beyond the limits of his empire. The message, in fact, strongly underlines the emperor’s self-proclaimed mission to pursue the promotion of moral zeal amongst all his subjects, whose continuous progress he will ensure by enlarging his imperial reach. There was nothing tentative about this mission. Instead, as Ashoka put it, the mission ‘will (be made to) progress considerably’. Thus, instructions were given on how he wanted it disseminated. These were fairly precise and required that the proclamation be sent everywhere, to the extremities of the district boundaries of the administrators to whom the instructions were addressed; and that in each